

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Twenty-One

Aggregations

*The accumulated weight of multiple matrices
converging on the same person*

Aggregations are the accumulated effect of multiple fundamental matrices converging on the same person. Unlike intersections (tight couplings), aggregations are loose piles: remove one constituent and the phenomenon diminishes but does not dissolve. Five aggregations: Beauty Standards, Manufactured Loneliness, Social Death / Invisibility, Burnout / Exhaustion, and Accelerated Slow Death.

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CHAPTER 21 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Aggregations

Aggregations are different from intersections. Intersections are tight couplings — every constituent is necessary, remove one and the phenomenon dissolves. Aggregations are loose piles — constituents contribute independently, remove one and the phenomenon diminishes but does not dissolve. The analogy from Chapter 1: a cake is an intersection (remove heat and you have batter); a pile of rocks is an aggregation (remove one rock and you have a smaller pile).

This chapter covers five aggregations: **Beauty Standards**, **Manufactured Loneliness**, **Social Death / Invisibility**, **Burnout / Exhaustion**, and **Accelerated Slow Death**. Each is briefly explained and followed by fill-in-the-blanks for personal study, as the framework's outline requires.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 through 20. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. The fill-in-the-blanks in this chapter ask you to study the aggregations in your own life and in the lives of people around you. The framework's point is that the suffering produced by aggregations is real, even though no single matrix is solely responsible. The suffering is the pile, not any single rock.

Contents

Aggregations	1
Contents	1
1. Beauty Standards	2
2. Manufactured Loneliness	3
3. Social Death / Invisibility	5
4. Burnout / Exhaustion	6
5. Accelerated Slow Death	7
6. Conclusion: Aggregations vs Intersections	8
References	8

AGGREGATION I

1. Beauty Standards

If you aggregate all the fundamental matrices that enforce appearance standards, you get Beauty Standards as an oppressive system. Colorism (Coloniality, Chapter 11) enforces light skin. Texturism (Coloniality) enforces loose or relaxed hair. Lookism (Somatic Normativity, Chapter 12) enforces the conventional face. Sizeism (Somatic Normativity) enforces the conventional size. Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) enforces gendered beauty standards. Amatonormativity (Chapter 14) enforces the couple-form beauty standard. Religious Dominance (Chapter 6) enforces modesty standards. Meritism (Chapter 16) enforces the influencer beauty standard.

The aggregation produces Beauty Standards as a system that is not seen as a neutral social phenomenon but as a ‘standard’ that is ‘enforced’ — making it oppressive rather than being about true beauty. The side effect is that nobody is allowed to be beautiful. Beauty is gatekept by the aggregation, and everyone is constantly comparing themselves and damaging their own self-esteem and that of others for zero benefit. The standard is impossible because it is an aggregation of contradictory demands: be light-skinned (Colorism) but not too light (some contexts); be thin (Sizeism) but not too thin (some Nigerian contexts); be relaxed (Texturism) but also be natural (the counter-movement); be modest (Religion) but also be attractive (Amatonormativity). The contradiction is the point: the aggregation cannot be satisfied because the constituents disagree.

Personal study. Which of the contributing matrices do you recognize most strongly in your own situation? _____. When did you first notice the aggregate weight rather than any single source? _____. What would change in your daily life if even one contributing matrix were removed? _____.

AGGREGATION 2

2. Manufactured Loneliness

The Intimacy Model (Brief)

The intimacy model used here is drawn from Kanter, Kuczynski, Manbeck, Corey, and Wallace's *An Integrative Contextual Behavioral Model of Intimate Relations* (2020), itself derived from the well-validated Interpersonal Process Model. In the model, intimacy is produced through a three-step dyadic exchange: (1) Person A engages in a vulnerable self-disclosure, (2) Person B enacts a responsive response, and (3) Person A perceives the response as responsive. If all three steps succeed, intimacy is produced. If any step fails, intimacy is sabotaged.

How the Aggregation Sabotages Intimacy at Each Step

Manufactured Loneliness is the aggregation of all fundamental matrices that possess an intrapersonal domain causing slow death, converging to isolate people and produce loneliness by sabotaging the intimacy model at each of its three steps.

Step 1 (Disclosure) is sabotaged because the subject cannot disclose vulnerably. Multiple matrices have taught them that their authentic self is deficient. Coloniality (Chapter 11) has taught them their skin is too dark, their hair is too kinky, their accent is too Nigerian, their knowledge is too indigenous. Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) has taught them their gender or sexuality is deviant. Adultism (Chapter 3) has taught them their youth means their voice does not count. The subject who has absorbed these internalised oppressions cannot disclose vulnerably, because vulnerability requires the belief that the authentic self is worth disclosing.

Step 2 (Response) is sabotaged because the potential responder cannot respond responsively. Multiple matrices have taught them to enforce rather than connect. Rankism (Chapter 2) has taught them to assert authority. Retributivism (Chapter 13) has taught them to punish. Religious Dominance (Chapter 6) has taught them to judge. Adultism (Chapter 3) has taught them to correct. The responder who has absorbed these internalised authorities cannot respond responsively, because responsiveness requires the suspension of enforcement.

Step 3 (Perception) is sabotaged because even when a responsive response is offered, the subject cannot perceive it as responsive. Multiple matrices have taught them to expect rejection. Internalised Oppression from every matrix has taught the subject that they are not worth responding to, that the response must be manipulative, that the responder must have an ulterior motive, that the kindness cannot be real. The subject who has absorbed these internalised oppressions cannot perceive the responsive response, because perception is filtered through the belief that they are not worth the response.

The result is **manufactured loneliness** — loneliness that is not the natural consequence of individual failure but the manufactured product of multiple matrices sabotaging intimacy at each step. The

subject is lonely not because they failed to reach out, but because the matrices made reaching out impossible. The subject is lonely not because the responder failed to respond, but because the matrices made responsive response impossible. The subject is lonely not because they failed to perceive the response, but because the matrices made perception impossible. The loneliness is manufactured by the aggregation, not chosen by the individual.

Personal study. Which of the contributing matrices do you recognize most strongly in your own situation? _____. When did you first notice the aggregate weight rather than any single source? _____. What would change in your daily life if even one contributing matrix were removed? _____.

AGGREGATION 3

3. Social Death / Invisibility

Social Death / Invisibility is the accumulated effect of multiple fundamental matrices that produce classification as a structural residue simultaneously rendering a person ‘not worth acknowledging.’ When Ethnic Majoritarianism (Chapter 17) classifies you as minority, Territorialism (Chapter 18) classifies you as non-indigene, Somatic Normativity (Chapter 12) classifies you as disabled or ugly, Coloniality (Chapter 11) classifies you as indigenous or backward, Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) classifies you as LGBTQ+ (criminalised under SSMPA 2014), Retributivism (Chapter 13) classifies you as criminal, and Productivism (Chapter 8) classifies you as unemployed — the aggregate effect is social death.

Social death is the condition of being rendered invisible, not worth acknowledging, not worth addressing, not worth including. The person who is classified as deficient by multiple matrices simultaneously is treated as if they do not exist. Their voice is not heard. Their presence is not acknowledged. Their suffering is not recognised. Their death is not grieved (Judith Butler’s ‘ungrievable lives’). The aggregation produces a visibility that is not the absence of any single classification but the compounding of multiple classifications into a total erasure.

The Nigerian example: the disabled, dark-skinned, non-indigene, ethnic-minority woman who is also LGBTQ+ and unemployed is rendered invisible by the aggregation of six or seven matrices simultaneously. No single matrix alone would produce this total erasure. Each matrix contributes its layer of classification. The aggregation produces the social death. The framework’s point is that this person’s invisibility is not the natural consequence of individual deficiency but the manufactured product of multiple matrices compounding their classifications.

Personal study. Which of the contributing matrices do you recognize most strongly in your own situation? _____. When did you first notice the aggregate weight rather than any single source? _____. What would change in your daily life if even one contributing matrix were removed? _____.

AGGREGATION 4

4. Burnout / Exhaustion

Burnout / Exhaustion is the accumulated labour extraction from fundamental matrices that extract labour of one form or another converging on the same person's daily energy budget. Productivism (Chapter 8) extracts wage-labour. Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) extracts domestic labour. Adultism (Chapter 3) extracts obedience labour. Kinship Normativity (Chapter 4) extracts loyalty labour. Religious Dominance (Chapter 6) extracts devotional labour. Enclosure (Chapter 7) extracts labour-to-afford-access. Retributivism (Chapter 13) extracts the labour of navigating the criminal justice system. Coloniality (Chapter 11) extracts the labour of performing the colonial standard.

The result is chronic fatigue, burnout, or the perpetual exhaustion that has no single identifiable cause. The WHO recognised burnout as an occupational phenomenon in 2019, but the framework's point is that burnout is not only occupational. It is the aggregation of labour extraction across multiple matrices. The Nigerian woman who works eight hours (Productivism), cooks and cleans for four hours (Cisheteropatriarchy), manages the children's homework for two hours (Adultism), attends the family event on Saturday (Kinship Normativity), attends church for three hours on Sunday (Religious Dominance), and navigates the colonial-era bureaucracy all week (Coloniality + Enclosure) is exhausted not because of any single matrix but because of the aggregation.

The exhaustion is often described as having no single identifiable cause because the cause is not any single extraction. The cause is the pile. The worker who is told to 'manage their time better' or 'practice self-care' is being told to solve an aggregation problem with an individual solution. The framework's point is that the exhaustion is manufactured by the aggregation of multiple matrices extracting labour simultaneously, and that the solution is not better time management but the dismantling of the matrices that extract the labour.

Personal study. Which of the contributing matrices do you recognize most strongly in your own situation? _____. When did you first notice the aggregate weight rather than any single source? _____. What would change in your daily life if even one contributing matrix were removed? _____.

AGGREGATION 5

5. Accelerated Slow Death

If you have a knife in your gut and a knife in your chest, you would die faster than if it was only one knife. Death (slow) in the Intrapersonal Domain is what a **single** matrix's Practice mechanism produces in the subject's body over time. Accelerated Slow Death is an **aggregation** of multiple matrices' Death (slow) outputs converging simultaneously.

Every fundamental matrix that has a stable intrapersonal domain produces Death (slow) in the subject's body. Coloniality (Chapter 11) produces the chronic stress of navigating Western standards with a Nigerian body. Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) produces the chronic stress of gendered surveillance. Productivism (Chapter 8) produces the chronic stress of compulsory productivity. Enclosure (Chapter 7) produces the chronic stress of rent burden. Retributivism (Chapter 13) produces the chronic stress of police encounters. State Sovereignty (Chapter 19) produces the chronic stress of checkpoint navigation. Somatic Normativity (Chapter 12) produces the chronic stress of beauty performance. Amatonormativity (Chapter 14) produces the chronic stress of couple-form enforcement. Each produces its own slow death. The aggregation accelerates the death.

The Nigerian who is Black (Coloniality), female (Cisheteropatriarchy), unmarried (Amatonormativity), childless (Kinship Normativity), disabled (Somatic Normativity), non-indigene (Territorialism), ethnic minority (Ethnic Majoritarianism), English-as-second-language (Coloniality / Linguicism), and poor (Enclosure + Productivism) is dying faster than any single matrix would predict — because the slow deaths from each matrix compound. The framework's point is that this person's premature death is not the natural consequence of any single condition but the manufactured product of multiple matrices' slow deaths converging. Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies at the aggregate level: the aggregation produces group-differentiated vulnerability to **accelerated** premature death.

***Personal study.** Which of the contributing matrices do you recognize most strongly in your own situation? _____. When did you first notice the aggregate weight rather than any single source? _____. What would change in your daily life if even one contributing matrix were removed? _____.*

CONCLUSION

6. Conclusion: Aggregations vs Intersections

Aggregations, unlike intersections, **can** be partially addressed by removing one contributing matrix. If you remove Colorism from the Beauty Standards aggregation, beauty standards become slightly less oppressive. If you remove Productivism from the Burnout aggregation, exhaustion becomes slightly less. If you remove Coloniality from the Manufactured Loneliness aggregation, the subject's capacity for vulnerable disclosure improves slightly. This is the difference between intersection (must be simultaneous) and aggregation (can be incremental).

But the framework's goal is still abolition of ALL matrices, not incremental reduction. Incremental reduction of an aggregation makes the pile smaller but does not eliminate it. The person who has six knives removed from their body still has the remaining knives. The framework's point is that 'zero' — the abolition and perpetual suppression of all oppressive systems — is the only goal worth striving for. Aggregations show why: even one remaining matrix contributes its rock to the pile, and the pile continues to produce its aggregated harm.

WHAT COMES NEXT

After this chapter, the framework continues with the **Other Topics of Note** chapter: Proximity to Elite / Classism (the composite position across all Stratification residues as a better explanation of class than classic classist theory), Oppression Olympics (a joke that became a thought experiment: if we intersected every fundamental oppressive system and identified the specific person who is subject to all of them, we would have found the most oppressed person in the world — and the suggestion that redesigning society with this person in mind would produce a vastly better world), and The Problem with Communism (communism as a rearrangement of fundamental matrices rather than emancipation, using China as the example).

References

This chapter draws on the theoretical framework established in Chapter 1 and the eighteen Fundamental Matrix chapters (Chapters 2-19). Key source for the Manufactured Loneliness aggregation:

1. Kanter, J. W., Kuczynski, A. M., Manbeck, K. E., Corey, M. D., & Wallace, E. C. (2020). An integrative contextual behavioral model of intimate relations. *Journal of Contextual Behavioral Science*, 18, 75–91. (Source for the intimacy model used in the Manufactured Loneliness aggregation — the three-step dyadic exchange of vulnerable self-disclosure, responsive response, and perceived responsiveness.)
2. Butler, J. (2009). *Frames of War: When Is Life Grievable?* Verso. (Source for the concept of ungrievable lives used in the Social Death / Invisibility aggregation.)

3. Gilmore, R. W. (2007). *Golden Gulag: Prisons, Surplus, Crisis, and Opposition in Globalizing California*. University of California Press. (Source for the definition of oppression as group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death, extended here to Accelerated Slow Death.)
4. World Health Organization. (2019). *Burn-out an 'occupational phenomenon': International Classification of Diseases*. WHO. (Source for the recognition of burnout as an occupational phenomenon, extended here to the Burnout / Exhaustion aggregation as multi-matrix.)